

Title: Strengthening Community Relationships for Effective Cancer Prevention and Screening: A Health Promotion Community Engagement Pilot

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Abstract:

In January 2024, BC Cancer's Prevention, Screening, and Hereditary Cancer Program implemented a community-level health promotion pilot to enhance awareness and engagement around cancer screening services and prevention information across British Columbia. This initiative incorporates in-person, event-based engagement activities supported by health promotion staff, allowing BC Cancer to broaden its impact within local communities. Key components include stakeholder engagement with post-secondary co-op programs, recruitment of students, and communication strategies to sustain participant engagement. Market research shows that 92% of BC residents are interested in cancer prevention and screening, with over 40% being "very interested". There is strong interest in topics such as nutrition, physical activity, air pollution, and sun safety. However, knowledge gaps, particularly among younger women and older adults, highlight the need for targeted outreach. Research shows that in-person community engagement initiatives can bridge these gaps by providing tailored information and fostering a sense of connection through shared experiences. The community engagement pilot provides vital information on breast, cervical, colon, and lung screening, along with prevention strategies for risk factors including sun safety, tobacco, alcohol, nutrition, air pollution, and radon. Engagement methods have included informational booths, presentations, and workshops. By building trusting relationships with community members and identifying local advocates, the pilot aims to address equity concerns and enhance the overall effectiveness of BC Cancer's outreach efforts. In its first eight months, the pilot has facilitated over 5,000 meaningful interactions with individuals interested in cancer prevention and screening. Interactive booths have been set up at diverse venues and events, such as malls, health conferences, farmers' markets, and community centers. To boost booth engagement, the health promotion team has created new promotional materials including vegetable seed kits, and colour-changing sun-safety wristbands to encourage positive behaviour change. A notable effort of the pilot is the collaboration with REACH Community Health Centre to conduct culturally safe workshops focusing on cervical and breast screenings and featuring the new HPV cervix self-screening kits. These workshops provide information and screenings to cultural communities facing barriers to access while building capacity and empowering women from various backgrounds. The completion of four targeted workshops expects to reach 160 women, fostering discussions about cancer screening within their families and communities. Through successful implementation of the community engagement pilot, BC Cancer strives to support health equity by actively engaging rural, Indigenous, and immigrant communities in cancer prevention and screening initiatives, ultimately enhancing public understanding of cancer risks, prevention strategies, and screening programs.

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